

Regular Meeting
November 16, 2015
School Committee Meeting
Council Chambers

The Regular Meeting of the Medford School Committee was called to order by Mayor McGlynn in the City Hall Council Chambers at 7:15 p.m. Those present were Ms. Cugno, Ms. DiBenedetto, Mr. Falco, Mr. Scarpelli, Mr. Skerry, Ms. Van der Kloot, Mayor McGlynn and Superintendent Belson.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry that the minutes of October 5, 2015 be approved:
Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Mr. Skerry that the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved:
Voted: That the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Falco, Scarpelli, Skerry, Van der Kloot, McGlynn
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto that the Payrolls be approved:
Voted: That the Payrolls be approved.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Falco, Scarpelli, Skerry, Van der Kloot, McGlynn
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot to suspend the rules

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Community Participation

Melanie McLaughlin from Medford's SEPAC was given permission to speak. Ms. McLaughlin invited the School Committee members to the SEPAC Basic Rights Seminar on Wednesday, November 18th at the Andrews Middle School from 7-9 pm and also the SEPAC meeting on December 9th also at the Andrews Middle School from 7:00 – 9:00 p.m. She stressed that all are welcome.

Superintendent Belson said that there is an approved trip to Washington D. C. which is to leave on Thursday morning. In light of what is happening that they would like to cancel the trip. All students have purchased the insurance which should reimburse them 75% and possibly 100% of the cost. This is still being finalized. It is a bad time with the current news.

Discussion:

Ms. Van der Kloot asked if the students have been informed? Ms. Ricciardelli said that no formal notification has been sent yet. Two parents have contacted school administrators. She said that all involved are very disappointed. Superintendent Belson stated that security is first and foremost. Ms. Cugno asked if there is any chance of rescheduling the trip? She also asked for a personal call to the parents. Ms. DiBendetto asked if any other schools were backing out? Ms. Ricciardelli replied no.

On the motion of approval the trip has been cancelled.

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Report on MIAA Sportsmanship Award

Superintendent Belson introduced Assistant Athletic Director Rachel Perry to present the report. Ms. Perry reported that each year the MIAA runs a sportsmanship essay/multimedia contest for high school students in Massachusetts. This year's topic was "Paying forward...How an Act of Sportsmanship Made a Difference in Your Life." Medford High School students Gigi Braga, Katrina Raschi and Victoria Raschi won first place in the MIAA contest with a video highlighting the Krystle Campbell scholarship fund started by Jack Dempsey and the Medford High School softball team. The students will present their video as honored guests during the 22nd annual MIAA Sportsmanship Summit at Gillette Stadium on Friday November 20, 2015. The students were presented with certificates from the School Committee.

Discussion:

Ms. Van der Kloot commented that she saw the video and is so proud of the students.

On the motion the report was accepted and placed on file.

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Mayor McGlynn requested a moment of silence for those who lost their lives and those who survived the tragedy in Paris this weekend.

A moment of silence was held.

Report on Foreign Language Scholarship Award

Superintendent Belson introduced Italian teacher Nichole Chalifoux to present the report. Ms. Chalifoux reported that Rachel Garland, a MHS AP Italian student recently received a \$1,000 scholarship from the Federazione Associazioni Abruzzesi - USA (FAA-USA) for her excellence in the study of Italian. The scholarship was awarded to Rachel on the evening of October 10th at the FAA-USA's annual gala celebration which took place at Filippo's restaurant in the North End of Boston. Rachel was accompanied to this event by her mother and three Italian teachers from Medford High School: Ms. Nicole Chalifoux, Ms. Monica

Canetta, and Ms. Bianca Hoffman. Another high school senior from Revere High School was awarded the second of the two scholarships given that evening. In order to qualify for the scholarship, Rachel had to submit an essay on the impact that studying Italian has had on her life and that evening she delivered her speech all in Italian. Present at the celebration were over 150 members of the Federation, many from out of state. Also present was the Consul General of Italy, Dr. Nicola De Santis, who conversed with Rachel in Italian. Rachel felt very honored, and all of us are very proud of this Medford High School senior.

On the motion of Mr. Falco the report was accepted and placed on file.

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Recommendation to Approve Trip to Puerto Rico

Superintendent Belson introduced Nelida Lepore to present the request. Ms. Lepore reported that the high school is requesting approval for a trip to Puerto Rico which will coincide with April vacation week 2016. Vamonos Tours, an educational travel agency, will be used again for this trip. This organization uses major airlines and provides professional liability and medical insurance. Ms. Lepore said that this trip will include dance lessons visiting schools and performing community service and attending a cooking class.

Discussion:

Ms. Cugno commented that this is a great opportunity but her only concern is that the students have the insurance. Ms. Lepore said that in light of what has recently happened perhaps the insurance should be mandatory. Ms. Cugno suggested making the insurance part of the package. Ms. DiBenedetto said that she loves the community service piece. She said that these students will return with more self esteem for helping.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry the trip is approved.

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Report on Medford Vocational School Open House

Superintendent Belson reported that the event was very well attended. He said that Ms. Riccio could not be in attendance tonight because of the recent passing of her mother. He said that we would further discuss the item when Ms. Riccio returns.

Discussion:

Ms. Cugno said that she has received a lot of positive feedback. She commented that it is a great opportunity for our students. Ms. DiBenedetto said that the facility looked great, the shops and the students looked wonderful. It was so nice to see the students show pride in their school. Mr. Falco said he attended as a parent and a school committee member. He said that the program has come a long way and you can see that the students are passionate about what they are learning. Ms. Van der Kloot said that Ms. Riccio's

report requested permission for students to attend the SkillsUSA fall conference on November 23rd.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto the trip was approved.

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

New Business:

School Committee Resolution

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Dr. Daniel Casullo. Dr. Casullo, a highly regarded dentist, was a graduate of Medford High School and former Captain of the varsity basketball team.

School Committee Resolution

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Madeleine Horrigan. Mrs. Horrigan was the mother-in-law of Medford Police Chief Leo Sacco Jr.

School Committee Resolution

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Alfred Palladino Jr. Mr. Palladino was the father-in-law of School Committee member John Falco.

School Committee Resolution

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Anne Marie Sanford. Mrs. Sanford was the mother of Medford teachers Lori Anne and Nicole Sanford.

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Barbara Steele Cassidy. Barbara was a Medford Public Schools Special Education Supervisor and a long time teacher. She was an outstanding professional who was well respected by her peers and was a caring friend to many.

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Elaine M. Donahue. Mrs. Donahue was the mother of Vocational Director Heidi Riccio.

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Michael Geiselman. Mr. Geiselman was a veteran who recently participated in the Veterans Day Program at Medford High School.

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Dawn Ferreira. Ms. Ferreira was a former custodian for the Medford Public Schools.

A moment of silence was held.

Report on Veterans Day Program

Director of Curriculum Bernadette Ricciardelli presented the report. She stated that to commemorate Veterans Day, the Humanities Department and the Office of Veterans Services worked together to sponsor the Veterans Day Speaker Program. In its fifteenth year, this program provides high school students and faculty with the opportunity to directly interact with veterans. Veterans visit high school classrooms discussing with students their combat and non-combat related experiences. The program is an enormously rewarding experience for all involved- our students, faculty and honored veteran guests. This year's program took place Thursday, November 5, 2015 and was co-coordinated by Director of Veterans Services, Mr. Earnest Lindsay; Director of Humanities, Nicole Chiesa and lead social studies teacher Nicholas Kain. The day began at 7:30 AM in the Superintendent's Conference Room with a light breakfast of coffee, donuts, juice, muffins, and fruit donated by Dunkin' Donuts in West Medford. Sandwiches and various salads were provided by the Food Services Department at the high school for lunch. Twenty-one veterans from several eras, including the Vietnam War, the Persian Gulf War, and the Iraq War visited thirty-eight classes and gave an overview of their military experiences and contributions. The program provided our students with an authentic oral history of personal experiences that will enhance their study of history in the classroom. Feedback from students, teachers, and veterans from this year's program was overwhelmingly positive.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto requested that letters from the School Committee be sent to the veterans.

On the motion of Ms. Cugno the report was accepted and placed on file.

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

Negotiations and Legal Matters - None

Report on National Assessment of Educational Progress (NAEP)

Superintendent Belson reported that the National Assessment of Educational Progress (NAEP) is referred to as the "Nation's Education Report Card." It is administered to a representative sample of 4th and 8th grade students nationwide in both reading and mathematics. Over three thousand Massachusetts randomly selected students took each of the four tests including students from Medford. The tests are given every two years. Massachusetts students ranked first in all grade levels for both subjects. This is the sixth consecutive administration of NAEP in which Massachusetts students have scored first or statistically tied for first place on all four NAEP test. The scale for scores on NAEP is 0-500. According to the 2015 NAEP results Massachusetts 4th graders had an average score of 235 in reading which was higher than our 2013 score of 232 and above the national average 221. Fifty percent of all Massachusetts students scored proficient or above which was significantly higher than the national average of 35 percent. The performance of students with disabilities grew eight points from 201 to 209. English Language Learners also increased eight points from 192 to 200. In grade eight reading Massachusetts students scored ten points above the national average (274 vs 264). The forty-six percent of Massachusetts students scored proficient or above which is thirteen points higher than the national average of thirty-three percent. The performance of students with disabilities and ELL students increased by one point

each compared to 2013. In grade four mathematics Massachusetts students scored 251 versus the national average of 240. Fifty-four Massachusetts students scored proficient versus the national average of thirty-nine percent. Students with disabilities dropped one point from 2013 to 231. ELL students remained the same at 223. In grade eight mathematics Massachusetts students dropped from 301 to 297 but remained significantly higher than the national average of 281. Fifty percent of Massachusetts students scored proficient or higher compared to a national average of thirty-five percent. The performance of students with disabilities dropped from 268 to 264. ELL students rose from 249 to 251. We will continue to review statistics generated by the NAEP and look at trends across the various assessment. Variations from year to year are best students in context with other assessments and in concert with changes in demography.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto commented that she is glad to see Massachusetts still ranked high nationally but globally more needs to be done.

On the motion of Mr. Scarpelli the report was accepted and placed on file.

Yes: 7

No: 0

Absent: 0

Update Report on PARCC Results and Status

Superintendent Belson reported that Commissioner Chester has released his formal recommendation to the DESE Board on the next generation of a Massachusetts Student Assessment. He has now formalized his call for a system he has entitled MCAS 2.0. This new instrument will blend the MCAS with PARCC. He appears to have the support of Board Chairperson and Secretary of Education James Peyser. There are groups on all four sides of this discussion. Those who want PARCC; those who want to keep MCAS; those who will support a hybrid (MCAS 2.0); and those who want to limit or abolish “high stakes” testing. If adopted the Commissioner’s new assessment system (MCAS 2.0) would be administered to all schools in the spring of 2017. Spring 2016 will be a transitional year for grades 3-8. A district that administered MCAS in 2015 will be allowed to continue with MCAS for 2016. There will be some PARCC like questions in this continuation in MCAS. Grade 10 in ELA and mathematics will continue to use MCAS. There will be proposals for 2017 if they can be developed in a timely way. The DESE Board has previously voted to retain the legacy MCAS as the high school determination through at least 2019. The new generation test would become the competency determination in 2020. The DESE Board is meeting in Malden on November 16-17th to discuss and potentially vote on the Commissioner’s recommendation or present their own proposals. We will keep you posted on the deliberations and decisions that are made by the DESE Board.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto said that she appreciated the handouts provided that they were very helpful. She said that she was amazed that the cost of testing is \$37million. She asked that the Superintendent keep them informed of any decisions. Mr. Skerry requested a Committee of the Whole meeting when the decision has been made.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry to hold a future Committee of the Whole to discuss the decision made by the DESE Board;

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Mr. Falco that the report be accepted and placed on file.

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Report on School Security

Superintendent Belson stated that this report is divided into five parts to enable us to better focus on the specific elements of our current school security plans and possible enhancements to our system. This report has multiple attachments to further describe and explain both current and possible security measures:

- McGlynn Incident
- Current Security Measures in Place
- Proposed Additional Security Measures
- Challenges
- Attachments

McGlynn Incident/ October 30, 2015:

On Friday, October 30, 2015 an unauthorized female adult entered the McGlynn School through the middle school side entrance around 12:30 p.m. She entered at the same time that seventh grade students were returning from recess. The door through which she entered was monitored by a lunch attendant and a teacher. She was not challenged at the point of entry. She then proceeded to the elementary side of the building and encountered a teacher who asked “may I help you?” The intruder responded she was just looking for a pen. She was not re-directed to the main entrance or further challenged. During the next half hour she went in and out of elementary classrooms and stole money (\$800 total) from six different teachers. The individual then left the building through the back door. No teachers or students were in the classrooms that she entered. Her progression into the parking lot; entrance into the school; movement through the school; exit; and drive away from the parking lot were captured on the school’s video camera surveillance system. The theft was reported by teachers to Elementary Principal Diane Guarino in the afternoon after students had left for the day. Principal Guarino reported the theft to the Superintendent who instructed her to file a police report. It was not clear at this time as to whether this was an “inside” or “outside” job. On Monday Allan Arena our Network Administrator reviewed the video surveillance (multiple hours) and identified the presence of a female intruder. The tape was provided to the police. The police shared the tape images with area police departments to alert them of a possible person of interest. The information was picked up by Fox Media. Fox began its coverage of the incident sometime Tuesday afternoon. The Superintendent spoke with Fox on Tuesday evening. The Superintendent emailed School Committee members early

evening describing the incident. Tuesday was a professional day in our schools so no students were present. The incident was not reported by the school administration from the outset to enable police to proceed with their pursuit of the intruder who probably did not know that she was on surveillance tape. We also hoped to avoid any panic/anxiety from parents coming to the school since students were not endangered at this time. Building administration intensified their security measures. As of this time the police have not identified the intruder. The Superintendent met with all principals and reviewed security protocols. Responses were provided to e-mail inquiries and the local press. Letters were sent home to parents. The incident at the McGlynn was not taken lightly. It resulted from "human error." No unauthorized person should ever be allowed to enter the schools without being challenged and re-directed to security. This element is correctable. Our schools are busy places and there are many individuals who must come and go on a daily basis. Unknown/unauthorized persons must always be stopped, challenged, and redirected to security.

Current Measures in Place

The Medford Public Schools takes school security very seriously. We were founding member of the NEMLEC STARS program that linked police to the schools on both a local and regional basis. All main buildings have the following:

- Documented security-emergency plans. Periodic drills are conducted at each building
- Coordinated detailed floor plans
- Surveillance cameras
- Door monitoring and main door buzzer system
- Shared police resource officers
- NEMLEC STARS
- Various ID's and sign-in requirements
- New enhanced phone systems
- Walkie Talkie and cell phones
- 911 access
- Emergency Medical Plans

Principals have met with the Superintendent and have reinforced the following at each building:

1. All doors must be locked at all times unless they are being monitored by an assigned member of the staff.
2. Non authorized individuals entering or traveling in our buildings must be stopped and questioned. They should be escorted to the main office for sign in.
3. Building guests must be wearing an appropriate ID badge issued by the school. If there is resistance or concern then assistance must be requested by notifying the office.
4. Alert the office if you see any strangers or suspicious individuals around or near the playground. If necessary, end recess and bring students into the building.
5. For those staff members who are providing services to outside students, please provide the main office a schedule of these appointments. The main office will call to your room when they arrive so you can escort them from the office to your room.
6. Those staff members who hold after school detentions, after school academic support, band practice, and the like must be stationed at the door as students are

exiting the building in order to ensure no individuals are entering the building unauthorized.

7. Remember to keep all valuables in a secure place at all times.
8. The office will support the staff member and call for police back-up (911)
9. A report will be filed with the principal
10. Principal will notify the Superintendent's Office.

Regular CBJ meetings are held weekly to review situations that require special attention. These meetings include school personnel, police department, representatives from the District Attorney's Office, and other relevant social service agencies.

Proposed Additional Security Measures in Addition to Existing Measures

1. Implement an enhanced ID system (Raptor Prototype) to ensure that all visitors have a picture pass on their possession when in our buildings (see attached material) Cost is about \$2000 per building. Vocational School is already in place.
2. Implement and install a security alert system at all main doors to provide a more rapid response when needed.
3. Consider selective placement of additional building monitors at high school complex.
4. Uniform dress for security personnel.
5. Improve notification with School Committee and parents when incidents occur consistent with best practices.

Challenges

- High school is a large facility with many doors/points of entry and multiple all day programs.
- Special events at every school where reasonable access is necessary
- Bus transportation
- Outdoor events
- Maintenance of security equipment
- Uniform and diligent implementation of security protocols by all faculty and staff

Attachments:

1. Medford Public Schools Crisis Response Manual
2. Massachusetts School Safety and Security Task Force Report
3. Suggested Procedures for Threat Assessment in Schools
4. Sample Emergency Response Procedures (McGlynn School)
5. Prototype ID System (Raptor)
6. Letter to McGlynn Parents

The safety of our students and staff is our highest priority. While there are challenges we have many important security elements in place. We will work together with our principals, teachers, staff, parents, law enforcement and community partners to enhance our capacity.

Discussion:

Ms. Van der Kloot began by suggesting that there was a weakness and thankful that only money was taken. She was upset that this happened on Friday and it was not until Monday that video surveillance was reviewed. Superintendent Belson said that it probably should have been done earlier but the first thought was that it was an inside job. Superintendent Belson said that he would accept the criticism. Ms. Van der Kloot said that the Superintendent dropped the ball and she is very disappointed. Mr. Skerry said

that he is deeply disturbed that a teacher and lunch attendant let a person walk in without asking them to identify themselves. He feels the need for identification for all staff. Superintendent Belson said that we have an identification system in all schools. The principals run drills in all schools. Mr. Skerry asked if the staff sign off after they have read the security manual? Mr. Falco said this is very concerning and he did not like the way that he heard about it. He thinks that the read and sign policy is a great idea. Mr. Edwards said that both middle and elementary schools go over the security protocol. Mr. Falco asked if students have id's because he feels that middle school and high school student should have them on at all time. Mr. Scarpelli concurs with his colleague that id's should be worn by all. Ms. DiBenedetto said that it is a refreshing report but that areas of weakness were shown. Also she said that the School Committee had previously voted regarding immediate notification by the Superintendent. She requested that a Committee of the Whole be held to further discuss security.

On the motion of Ms. DiBenedetto to hold a Committee of the Whole pertaining to security:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Ms. Cugno stated that isn't this incident common sense. If you don't know who they are then don't let them in! It is done and it can't be changed. She agrees with the id's for students and staff. She also said that staff needs to abide by protocol. Superintendent Belson said that I am responsible for the school system. You have given me suggestions and we will meet again to continue this discussion. Lets not cause fear in the community. Our schools are safe and we need to send this message out. He also said that he wants it to be known that information was not withheld because of the city election. It had nothing to do with that. He said it is best practice to let the police go ahead with their investigation but he should have notified the School Committee. We will improve.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry the report was accepted and placed on file.

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Ms. DiBenedetto said that this is her third time requesting the Community School's budget and a report on rentals. Superintendent Belson said it is planned for the next agenda.

On the motion that meeting be adjourned at 8:55 p.m.

Respectfully submitted:

Robert E. Skerry Jr
Secretary

